

Weaving Indigeneity and Culture into the Fabric of HCI Futures

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Abstract

Interconnectedness and relationality have become integral to technology development and innovation, which has led to indigenous and cultural philosophies and approaches becoming important in developing effective and inclusive design practices. This workshop challenges the dominant paradigms in Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) by exploring the potential of indigeneity and culture to inform design methodologies. We invite participants to reflect on how such approaches can move HCI research toward more inclusive, culturally diverse, and mutually beneficial synergies. Through constructive conflict and co-creation, we aim to illuminate the potential of indigenous and cultural approaches in HCI practice, inspiring vital shifts towards decolonial and pluralistic design. We welcome HCI researchers and practitioners and indigenous scholars and experts interested in disrupting traditional methods and embracing indigenous and cultural lenses to join this critical conversation.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → *Field studies*; **Participatory design**.

Keywords

indigenous practices, community, futuring, connectedness

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1 Introduction

Indigenous philosophies and cultural frameworks are often overlooked as appropriate sources of inspiration for methodologies and approaches in HCI. To highlight one such example, Ubuntu, a Southern African philosophy, emphasises values of interconnectedness, compassion, and human dignity [5, 11]. From a Western perspective, individualism has often been embedded within HCI design, with technologies focused on individuals, whereas Ubuntu can offer a counterpoint to traditional HCI practice. In this way, users and participants are considered as embedded within their communities, bringing with them their intersectional identities [6] and histories [16]. This has implications for the design of interfaces and systems, where researchers can consider the needs of communities superseding that of the individual - a re-prioritisation that promotes interdependence and collaboration [22]. A community-oriented approach, rooted in the philosophy of Ubuntu, can thus provide opportunities for considering socio-economic and historical barriers to technology access, embracing an intersectional viewpoint [6], beyond just individual capabilities.

Ubuntu is but one philosophy that has the potential of informing HCI work, shifting research towards new, interesting, and uncomfortable places. There remains an opportunity to explore how approaches rooted in indigenous philosophies and underrepresented cultures can inform HCI work to create mutually beneficial, innovative, and culturally diverse partnerships. Moreover, there is a need to understand how to practically embrace indigenous values in HCI, expanding on the need to build bridges between theory and practice. In this CHI workshop, we invite participants to reflect on indigenous philosophies and culture within their work in the HCI domain, while also challenging the status quo of CHI for the better. We intend to create a constructive conflict [7] environment, focused on innovation and reinvention, that pushes participants and the broader HCI community to grapple with the tensions between indigenous and cultural approaches as well as the history of the adoption of these frameworks (or lack thereof) in CHI activities. We envision the co-creation of a space of thinking and evolution that will be an ongoing living framework as researchers continue to learn and innovate the way they practice HCI. We aim to illuminate the absence of indigenous and cultural approaches in HCI practice

and allow the tension and conflict to inspire new and vital shifts for the CHI community. We draw from the conference theme "Ikigai" and the "Sakura" (cherry blossom) as we intend to explore where we as a community wish to see CHI in the future, what an inclusive and embracing CHI looks and feels like, and how to embark on the renewal and re-imagining of our community.

This workshop is an iteration of one that was held at the Participatory Design Conference in 2024 [9]. It differs in that the previous workshop was Ubuntu-focused and framed in terms of communal philosophies primarily, whereas this workshop expands our viewpoint and vision to include indigeneity and culture and a shaping of the future of CHI. We lean on previous CHI contributions such as Baughan et al.'s [3] SIG on Designing for Constructive Conflict, Kotut et al.'s [12] work with indigenous oral communities and their reflections on methods, and Szaniecki et al.'s [23] explorations into "participation otherwise" as a response to Arturo Escobar's call to design for/by the Global South [8]. We expect that this workshop, associated with the conference and its themes, will attract HCI researchers working from/in the Global South as well as practitioners interested in building concrete decolonial and indigenous-inspired approaches while also disrupting traditional methods. We hope for our workshop to support HCI practitioners in expanding ways of conducting HCI research and evolving the CHI community, considering the inherent inter-connectedness of communities and their members while embracing approaches that acknowledge a pluralistic lens of the world. The timing of this workshop comes during a period of reflection for the CHI community, as it looks towards its global footprint and community at large, acknowledging its position, history, and contributions, while also constantly seeking to renew and remain optimistic about our role in addressing pertinent challenges.

2 The turn towards indigeneity in HCI

Initially Human Computer Interaction (HCI) practice and research focused predominantly on "universal approaches" mostly originating from the west. Often neglecting the rich cultural nuances and knowledge systems that inform diverse ways of interaction. Scholars began to acknowledge that technology is not a universal solution but rather a context-dependent construct influenced by societal norms and values [1]. Hence, over the past decade, HCI is going through a turn to cultural and push for inclusivity with workshops as spaces for pluralist perspectives [21], promoting intersectionality within SIGCHI [26], decolonisation in HCI [14] and more. Though, indigenous knowledge and practice usually gets considered as niche and excluded from the global HCI movement. It is imperative to provide a space for collective learning, valuing tensions, sitting in discomfort and healing for researchers, practitioners, students and anyone who is interested in engaging with indigenous practices and philosophies.

By centering the voices of marginalized communities, HCI can foster more ethical and responsible design practices that acknowledge and address historical injustices. Benford et al. explore the ethical dimensions of cultural experiences in HCI, particularly the concept of "uncomfortable interactions" that can provoke deeper engagement and understanding [4]. This perspective is crucial when considering the historical and ongoing impacts of colonialism and

systemic inequities in technology design. Rankin and Henderson emphasize the importance of recognizing how race, gender, and class shape technology design and usage, advocating for a critical framework that resists systemic racism and promotes equity in HCI practices [20]. Winschiers-Theophilus and Bidwell advocate for an Afro-Centric Indigenous HCI paradigm, emphasizing the need to localize software and design practices to reflect the cultural contexts of users [25]. Such an approach not only respects cultural differences but also enhances user experience by ensuring that technologies resonate with the values and practices of the communities they serve.

The intersection of technology and cultural heritage is another critical area where indigenous philosophies can inform HCI. Liu's exploration of grassroots heritage in crisis contexts demonstrates how social media can facilitate culturally sensitive design practices that honor community narratives and experiences [15]. This approach aligns with the need for HCI to move beyond superficial cultural adaptations and engage deeply with the cultural contexts of users, as highlighted by Haddad et al. [10]. By integrating cultural heritage into design processes, HCI can create technologies that resonate with users on a personal and communal level. The implications of integrating indigenous and underrepresented cultural perspectives extend to addressing structural inequalities within technology development. HCI research has increasingly focused on community empowerment, recognizing that technological solutions should not merely aim to "fix" systemic issues but rather engage with communities in meaningful ways. The ethos of inclusivity found within Indigenous cultures is also crucial for informing HCI practices. Engaging Indigenous communities in the design process ensures that their values and traditions are respected and integrated into technological solutions. The 7 Grandfather teachings—Love, Respect, Courage, Truth, Humility, Wisdom, and Honesty—serve as guiding principles that can cultivate a culture of inclusion and healing within HCI frameworks [2].

3 Key Questions

This one-day workshop aims to understand and make visible the current use of indigenous and cultural practices in HCI. Through co-design, we will then explore guidelines and points of departure to embed indigeneity within HCI practice. Through workshop activities, participants will engage with the following questions:

- How is indigeneity and culture being practised in HCI?
- What resources are currently available to learn and practice indigeneity within HCI?
- How can indigeneity support and inform HCI approaches?
- What are pathways ahead for an indigenous-centric approach in HCI?
- What HCI future should we envision where indigenous and cultural philosophies are fully embraced?

4 Workshop aim and goals

Our workshop will bring together a diverse group of practitioners, researchers, educators, students, and industry partners from the field of HCI. Together, we'll explore ways to foster inter-connectedness, compassion, and deep respect for humanity within our work. By

embedding these values into HCI design, we aspire to create technologies, methods, processes, frameworks, and infrastructure that genuinely serve and empower communities. During the workshop, we aim to accomplish the following goals:

- (1) Map ecologies of indigenous- and culture-led practices and identifying actionable aspects for implementation.
- (2) Investigating drawbacks, critiques, and experiences related to incorporating indigenous and cultural principles in design and collaboration as well as other HCI academic activities.
- (3) Formulate a set of guidelines, to be iterated upon, that serve as a reference for researchers, in HCI, to work towards embracing indigenous, cultural, and community-centric approaches in their work.
- (4) Create an artefact that encapsulates the future of CHI in a world that has already embraced indigenous and cultural ideas, approaches, and concepts.

5 Organisers

Jaydon Farao is a PhD researcher in Computer Science at the University of Cape Town whose research is situated at the intersection of human-computer interaction, digital storytelling, and participatory design. He has a particular interest in supporting community well-being in under-resourced contexts through digital technologies and innovations while leveraging community-based co-design and intersectional approaches to design. He is experienced in running co-design workshops especially in culturally diverse settings [24]. He also served as the Participation Chair for the Participatory Design Conference in 2024 and is the current Global Inclusion and Equity Chair for CHI 2025, both roles focused on acknowledging diverse participation and alternative modes of engagement.

Ajit G. Pillai is a PhD candidate at The University of Sydney. His PhD is focused on understanding the experience of ethical tensions faced by tech workers, designers and students. His research utilises an iterative participatory design approach to co-create knowledge derived from the diverse experiences of people from different parts of the world. The objective of his PhD is to build a care-based infrastructure for tech workers, students and educators that values their intersectionality and complex experience of ethical tensions within varied contexts of technology design.

Hafeni Mthoko is the co-founder of NutureID8 (www.nutureid8.net) and a member of faculty at Varsity College. She has experience in monitoring and evaluating ICTD-related interventions in rural contexts, citizen engagement, and health communicative ecologies. She has an interest in identifying innovative ways, including technology, to facilitate meaningful change in African settings. She has a particular interest in exploring mentorship approaches to better support aspiring researchers. She has extensive experience in conducting workshops, recently co-facilitating workshops at AfriCHI 2023 [13, 19] and COMPASS 2023 [18].

Marly Muudeni Samuel is a PhD candidate with the School of Innovation and Technology at the Glasgow School of Art. Her research focuses on the use of immersive technologies and photogrammetry to record and preserve ocean heritage in Namibia. Adopting the methodologies of participatory design and co-production, Marly has collaborated with coastal communities to create the augmented

reality application – Efuta Letu Sida Hurib — that captures knowledge, practices and values related to the ocean. Marly has previously worked with marginalised communities in Namibia promoting inclusive access to technology and equitable sustainable development. She is passionate about employing digital technologies and HCI to promote and improve education, information and technology access and heritage preservation.

Houda Elmimouni is an Assistant Professor in the Department of Computer Science at the University of Manitoba, Canada. Her work intersects Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) and Computer-Supported Cooperative Work (CSCW) with a focus on aligning technology with human values such as privacy, identity, and inclusion. Her current research delves into the role of telepresence in hybrid learning environments and how robots can contribute to inclusive education. She has a strong interest in exploring indigenous philosophies within HCI practice, particularly how these communal and care-centered approaches can inform the design of inclusive technologies. She holds a PhD from Drexel University and has been recognised with multiple awards, including the CRA Computing Innovation Fellowship and Fulbright Fellowship.

Shaaïma Lazem is an Associate Research Professor at the City of Scientific Research and Technological Applications (SRTA-City), Egypt. She earned her PhD in Computer Science from Virginia Tech, USA with a focus on Human-Computer Interaction (HCI). Her interests include participatory design, community-based design, and Human-centered AI. She is a Leaders-in-Innovation Fellow with the Royal Academy of Engineering in London, and the co-founder of the ArabHCI community. She works on localising Responsible Human-Centered AI in the African tech ecosystem in partnership with Prof. Anicia Peters from Namibia with support from Google 2020 Award for Inclusion Research and Google AI 2021 Awards.

6 Website

The workshop website will be hosted at <https://sites.google.com/view/weavingfuturechi>.

We will post the call for participation, position contribution (paper, video, artwork, other media) deadlines, detailed activities about the workshop and accepted position contributions on this platform. Once the workshop has been completed, we will update the web-page to reflect on the outcomes for the CHI community, and interested practitioners, to access. We will continue using the website as a forum for discussion and community-building around indigenous- and cultural-led HCI practice, as well as decolonial approaches, in the future. The following dates are the proposed timeline for applicants:

- Call for participation: 15 December 2024
- Position contribution due: 13 February, AoE
- Notifications of acceptance: 20 February, AoE

7 Pre-workshop plans

The call for participation will be advertised through personal contacts, professional networks, social media and mailing lists. Furthermore, we will directly contact researchers and practitioners who are likely to be interested in the workshop including potential keynote speakers. We will be inviting researchers or experts from the Ainu indigenous community as Potential keynote speakers,

with the intention of connecting to the physical place of the venue of CHI 2025, but also to introduce the ways in which indigeneity and culture can support the goals of this workshop. Participants, who will include HCI researchers, scholars who do work with indigenous communities, researchers concerned with culture and research, as well as CHI community members interested in pushing the boundaries of what CHI and research can be, are invited to submit a short position contribution to the workshop in order to express their interest. Those who are accepted will be invited to present their work at the workshop, publish it on the workshop website, partake in workshop activities, and contribute to a future publication. We expect 15-20 participants for this workshop. Participants will be asked to submit their position contribution within the following themes:

- **Understanding Indigeneity and Culture in the Network:** Explore how Indigenous philosophies and cultural practices can be applied to build malleable and porous natures within HCI practice, fostering a sense of interconnectedness and shared responsibility in practical terms.
- **Shaping External Inputs within Indigenous and Cultural Practices:** Investigate the integration of external elements, such as design, artifacts, and time, into Indigenous and Cultural practice, ensuring they are molded in a way that aligns with community needs and values.
- **Shifting from Individualistic to Communal Technology Relationships:** Examine the shift from an individualistic perspective on technology to viewing it as a communal artefact. Exploring the relational aspects of interacting with technology and discussing collaborative approaches within Communal frameworks.
- **Addressing Gaps in Community-centric Design:** Evaluate existing philosophies on communities in Participatory Design Conference (PDC) settings, identifying gaps and exploring how Indigenous principles can contribute to more inclusive, decolonial, and community-centric design practices.

8 Workshop structure

The workshop will be a one-day hybrid session due to the nature of the topic involving people from different continents and contexts and to retain the capability to create and share knowledge with contributors from underrepresented regions, unable to attend CHI in-person. Most of the workshop will be conducted synchronously where we aim to share the knowledge created collectively, with prior engagements and discussions occurring in the weeks leading up to the workshop, especially for those with timezone constraints. We acknowledge that CHI taking place in Japan poses time constraints for those joining remotely from South America (a time difference of ± 12 hours) and Africa (± 7 hours). We will attempt to accommodate these virtual attendees at appropriate times with additional asynchronous engagements prior to the workshop. The online workshop will be conducted via Zoom and Miro by two of the organisers who have experience in conducting workshops virtually, adapting activities to be suitable and engaging for remote participants. The structure of the workshop is detailed below with a proposed schedule in Table 1.

Introduction and keynote: The workshop will begin with an ice-breaker and networking activity. This will be an opportunity for participants to share their positionality and their outlook for the workshop activities. Since we anticipate some constructive conflict and positive exploration of new ideas, we aim to ensure that participants can contribute freely and productively, encouraging the embracing of new and underrepresented perspectives. This will be followed by an introduction to the workshop topic and activities by the organisers. Next, an invited keynote speaker will give a 30-40 minute speech followed by short Q&A.

Lightening position contribution presentation: participants will briefly present their proposals to give the group an opportunity to become familiar with current approach and vision.

Yarning circle: This Australian indigenous practice [17] focuses on narratives and personal experiences of individuals connected to their environment and place. This activity will be guided to capture the current landscape of indigeneity and culture in HCI used by participants in research, teaching, and practice. The exercise involves working in groups and using a set of visual templates and post-it notes provided by the organisers. Participants will start by sharing personal stories, then identifying challenges and opportunities based on their experiences.

Speculative obituaries activity: This activity is inspired by the Egyptian philosophy of creating something with its end in mind. The pyramids included a space where the future inhabitants could keep their favourite possessions, food and other tools that they could use in the afterlife. In this activity, we will be writing an obituary for the end of life of "turn to indigeneity in HCI". This will include prompts regarding what caused its death, the trajectory, its high points and low points in the HCI community and more. This speculation on the death of a movement also allows us to trace back to how we should begin and map the steps we as a community need to take to further develop and embed it within HCI.

Final discussion: Finally, those who worked in groups will present their speculated futures. All participants will engage in a discussion around the opportunities for scaffolding indigeneity and culture in HCI and reflect on how a collective future may be built. Participants will then be invited to contribute to a statement of mission to achieve this future.

Wrap up: The workshop will end with a self-reflection during which participants will identify how they will use the insights from the workshop in their practice. A final keynote will motivate participants and groups to continue the conversation and incorporate their learnings into their respective domains as they re-imagine an Indigenous-centric design approach.

Table 1: Proposed Schedule

Workshop Schedule	Activity
09:00-09:45	Welcome and keynote
09:45-10:30	Lightening position contribution presentation A
10:30-11:00	Break
11:00-12:00	Yarning Circle
12:00-12:30	Conclusion of first exercise
12:30-13:30	Lunch Break
13:30-14:30	Lightening position contribution presentation B
14:30-15:30	Speculative obituaries activity
15:30-16:00	Break
16:00-16:30	Final discussion and Wrap up (Bringing all the sessions together)

9 Post-Workshop plans

Workshop outputs, including materials created during the co-creation session as well as the positioning contributions, will be shared with the wider HCI community through our website and a planned subsequent publication to which participants will be invited as authors. We will also discuss plans for future outputs with workshop attendees on the day, as we aim to build a community focused on reimagining the potential for CHI as a global community.

10 Call for participation

"Weaving Indigeneity and Culture into the Fabric of HCI Futures

This one-day, hybrid CHI 2025 workshop calls upon practitioners, researchers, educators, and students in HCI interested in reimagining methods and approaches in HCI through the lens of indigeneity and cultural practices, but also to envision what CHI can work towards when embracing underrepresented ways of being. Our aims are to understand how indigeneity is currently practised within HCI, identify ways to amplify its impact through interactive experiences and a transgression of traditional practices, and chart a course for future development. Outcomes will include a shared understanding of indigeneity and culture as a conduit for the growth of CHI, collaborative resources for teaching and applying indigenous principles, and the emergence of a toolkit that guides this mindset based on participant contributions and co-created artefacts. We invite you to participate! Share your work and perspectives, reflect on your practices in light of an indigenous and cultural lens, and engage with

others in the community. Submit a position contribution outlining your interest, focusing on:

- Case studies
- Literature/curriculum reviews
- Indigenous-centered projects
- Ethical considerations
- New resources that could bolster the integration of indigeneity and culture in HCI work holistically

Position contributions should be 2-4 pages long (excluding references) in the ACM SIGCHI Article template. Alternative media formats (audio, artwork, photo essays, video) are also accepted. Submissions will be juried by the organisers based on originality and relevance. Submissions and questions should be emailed to jaydon.farao11@gmail.com. At least one author of each accepted paper must attend the workshop. More information can be found here:

<https://sites.google.com/view/weavingfuturechi>

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